

The cursives range in date from the IX to the XVII centuries. The heavy majority of them, some 2,130, are bunched in four centuries: XI – XIV. Around 90 of them are rather fragmentary, and many more are not complete. Around 25 of them have a number, but so little is known about them that they evidently are not available; and as many more have disappeared from sight. Even so, there are enough left to keep us busy for a long, long time.

Until the invention of paper, the materials used for making copies were papyrus and parchment (leather), both of which are thicker than paper. A complete NT bound in one volume would be rather bulky, and quite expensive. So early on, the books started to be bound in smaller groups: the four Gospels, the letters of Paul (including Hebrews), Acts and the General Epistles, with Revelation added on here and there. The Gospels were by far the most popular, followed by Paul’s letters. At this writing, we know of around 2,350 MSS (including fragments) that contain some part of the Gospels, around 800 that contain some part of Paul’s letters, over 650 that contain some part of Acts, over 600 that contain some part of the Generals, and about 300 that contain some part of Revelation. We know of around 60 complete New Testaments, another 150 that contain all but Revelation, and around 270 that contain Acts through Jude.

Not all of the above will be available for an interested person to work with. Consider the Gospels: of the 2,350 MSS mentioned above, for any single Gospel (like John) the number will be around 2,000. But because of fragments, damage and lacunae, for any given verse the number will be around 1,700. The INTF in Münster, Germany, holds microfilms of almost all of them. **However**, such an interested person needs to understand that he is not dealing with 1,700 independent witnesses—those MSS represent a variety of lines of transmission, or ‘families’; such families would be the witnesses.¹ But there will be inter-relationship between families, and to be sure about such relationships we need a scientifically elaborated reconstruction of the history of the transmission of the NT Text. Lamentably, no such reconstruction exists. Worse, due to the soporific effect of the Hortian theory, the families have yet to be defined. I have scientifically defined Family 35 for the whole NT, but so far as I know, no other family

¹ Frederik Wisse collated and compared 1,386 MSS in Luke 1, 10 and 20 (three chapters); he reduced those MSS to 37 groups (families) (plus 89 “mavericks”). *The Profile Method for the Classification and Evaluation of Manuscript Evidence* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1982). It happens that 36 of the 37 fall within the broad Byzantine river of transmission. He found 70 subgroups within the 36, so felt able to define those relationships, based on the profiles. I submit that this is a step in the right direction.